

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Retail and E-Commerce English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For retail managers, e-commerce teams, merchandising staff, store operations leaders, fulfillment teams, customer service managers, marketplace sellers, and growth operators.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

A/B test

Controlled comparison of two variants to estimate the effect of a change on a defined outcome.

allocation

The assignment of available resources, stock, or capacity to particular uses.

assortment

The selection of products offered by a retailer.

BOPIS

Buy online, pick up in store: a retail order and collection arrangement.

cannibalization

Sales of one offering replacing sales of another offering from the same business.

carrier

A company that transports goods or people; in insurance, an insurer.

cart abandonment

Leaving an online shopping cart without completing the purchase.

chargeback

A reversal of a card transaction through the payment network's dispute process.

conversion rate

The proportion of an identified group that completes a specified desired action.

customer lifetime value

An estimate of a customer's economic value over the relationship under stated assumptions.

defect rate

The proportion of items counted as defective under a stated definition and denominator.

fulfillment

The process of preparing and delivering a customer's order.

funnel

A sequence of stages people move through toward a defined outcome.

goodwill credit

A discretionary credit offered under a company's service process to address a customer experience.

gross margin

Revenue minus cost of goods sold, expressed as an amount or a percentage of revenue.

inventory accuracy

How closely stock records match actual quantities and locations.

inventory turn

How often inventory is sold or used over a stated period, based on a defined calculation.

labor model

A plan or calculation describing staffing needs and deployment.

markdown

A reduction in a product's selling price, often to improve stock movement.

marketplace

A platform where multiple sellers offer goods or services to buyers.

promotion

An activity intended to increase attention or sales, sometimes using a temporary price offer.

queue

A list of items or people waiting for processing or service.

replenishment

Replacing stock that has been used or sold.

return policy

The conditions under which a retailer accepts returned purchases.

return rate

The proportion of purchases or units returned under a stated calculation.

sell-through

The proportion of available stock sold during a defined period using a stated calculation.

SKU

Stock keeping unit: an identifier for a distinct inventory item.

SLA

Service-level agreement defining expected service performance or response commitments.

stockout

A situation in which an item is unavailable when it is needed.

vendor scorecard

A set of defined measures used to review a supplier's performance.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Merchandising and Assortment Planning

Two product ranges have similar sales revenue, but one sells through more slowly and requires larger markdowns.

The revenue totals are similar, but their inventory and markdown patterns differ. Let's compare sell-through and margin as well before deciding which range is performing better.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Pricing, Promotions, and Margin

A promotion increases units sold by 20%, while the selling price falls by 15%. A team member assumes profit must have increased.

Higher unit sales do not by themselves show higher profit. We need the price, cost, and mix effects. I'll separate volume growth from the margin question in the promotion review.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Inventory, Allocation, and Replenishment

A product is available in one warehouse but out of stock in several stores. The website uses a single national inventory total.

The national total hides local shortages. I'll report availability by location and check the replenishment status so customers and store teams receive a more useful update.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Fulfillment, Shipping, and Returns

A customer receives an estimated delivery date that has already passed. The carrier has not confirmed a new arrival time.

I'm sorry the estimated date has passed. I am checking the shipment status with the responsible team. I'll give you the next verified update and explain the available options under our service process.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Conversion, UX, and Digital Analytics

Checkout conversion falls after a redesign, but payment outages occurred in the same period.

The decline overlaps with both the redesign and payment outages. We should investigate those factors before attributing the change to the design alone.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Marketplace and Vendor Management

A vendor scorecard records a high defect rate but does not define the denominator or reporting period.

Could you confirm whether the rate is based on units, orders, or inspected samples, and for which period? We need a consistent basis before discussing vendor performance.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Customer Service and Escalations

A customer requests a return outside the stated policy. The representative can explain approved options but cannot invent an exception.

I understand why you are asking. Let me explain the available options under the policy and check whether the appropriate team can review your circumstances. I cannot promise an exception before that review.

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Store Operations and Omnichannel Execution

A pickup order is marked ready online, but staff cannot find one item. The next shift needs to resolve the discrepancy.

The order is marked ready, but one item has not been located. Please verify the stock and update the order status through our process before confirming pickup to the customer.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Retail and E-Commerce English

Professional audience: retail managers, e-commerce teams, merchandising staff, store operations leaders, fulfillment teams, customer service managers, marketplace sellers, and growth operators

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Merchandising and Assortment Planning

Original fictional case: Two product ranges have similar sales revenue, but one sells through more slowly and requires larger markdowns.

Language workshop: Explain a fair comparison

Communication goal: Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

Language guidance: Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Both options ..., but ... / Option A ..., whereas option B ... / The comparison depends on ...

Vocabulary: assortment: The selection of products offered by a retailer. / SKU: Stock keeping unit: an identifier for a distinct inventory item. / sell-through: The proportion of available stock sold during a defined period using a stated calculation. / gross margin: Revenue minus cost of goods sold, expressed as an amount or a percentage of revenue.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The revenue totals are similar, but their inventory and markdown patterns differ. Let's compare sell-through and margin as well before deciding which range is performing better.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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END REFERENCE

TASK: A short retrieval session

1. Tell me to close my notes. Plan six questions: two vocabulary-in-context items, one grammar or meaning contrast, one question about a confirmed versus unknown detail, one short spoken-style response and one new-situation transfer task. Use the supplied material as the answer reference, but do not repeat its existing checks word for word.
2. Ask only the first question, then stop and wait. Prefer a short answer over a multiple-choice question. Do not display the remaining questions, model answers or a word bank in advance.
3. After each answer, say what it gets right and explain a meaningful error if there is one. Accept alternative wording when it preserves the facts and does the communication job. If I struggle, give one clue and invite a retry before revealing a model. Only then move to the next question.
4. Keep a simple record of which items I answered independently, with a hint, or after seeing a model. This records today's practice, not a certified proficiency score. Do not judge pronunciation from typed text.
5. At the end, summarize two strengths and two useful next steps with examples from my answers. Give me a small review card containing three prompts and a separate answer section. Suggest that I revisit it tomorrow and a week later; do not claim you will remember this session or send reminders. Label the final transfer scenario as fictional.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level